

MODULE 03 · DOMAIN 1 - CLOUD CONCEPTS

Migration Strategies and Tooling

The seven Rs, and the services that move an estate onto AWS.

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Migration questions describe a situation and ask you to **name the strategy**. The names are fixed. The situations are not.

The seven Rs

STRATEGY	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS
Rehost	Lift and shift. Move it as it is, change nothing.
Replatform	Lift, tinker and shift. Small optimisations, same core application.
Repurchase	Drop and shop. Abandon it and buy a SaaS product instead.
Refactor	Re-architect. Rewrite it to use cloud-native services.
Retire	Switch it off. Nobody was using it.
Retain	Leave it where it is, for now. Revisit later.
Relocate	Move infrastructure wholesale without changing operations.

ON THE EXAM

Seven, not six. Relocate is the one most study material omits, and Retire is the one people forget is a strategy at all.

Giveaway phrases for each strategy

IF THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE STRATEGY IS
Move it with no code changes, quickly	Rehost
Move the database to Amazon RDS, application unchanged	Replatform
Replace our system with a SaaS subscription	Repurchase
Rewrite the monolith as serverless functions	Refactor
Discovery found nobody has used it in a year	Retire
A compliance rule means it cannot move yet	Retain
Move the whole VMware estate without re-buying hardware	Relocate

ON THE EXAM

Read for what happened to the application itself. Unchanged, tweaked, replaced, rewritten, deleted, left alone, or moved wholesale.

Rehost or Replatform?

REHOST

Nothing about the application changes

- Same operating system, same code
- Fastest route off the data centre
- No cloud benefits gained yet
- Often the first step, optimised later

REPLATFORM

One component swapped for a managed one

- Self-managed database becomes Amazon RDS
- Application code stays as it is
- Some operational burden removed
- Slower than rehost, cheaper to run

THE TIEBREAKER

If a managed AWS service replaces a component, it is replatform. If literally nothing changed, it is rehost.

Refactor or Repurchase?

REFACTOR

You rewrite it yourself

- Monolith becomes microservices or serverless
- Highest cost and effort of the seven
- Highest long-term benefit too
- You still own the software

REPURCHASE

You stop owning it

- Self-hosted CRM becomes a SaaS subscription
- No code to maintain afterwards
- Licensing model changes entirely
- Someone else owns the software

THE TIEBREAKER

Refactor keeps your software and changes its shape. Repurchase throws your software away and rents someone else's.

The three people forget

- ◆ **Retire is a real strategy.** Discovery routinely finds a tenth of an estate that nobody uses.
- ◆ Retiring is the cheapest possible migration outcome. It is often the correct answer.
- ◆ **Retain means deliberately not moving** because of latency, compliance, or a licence that will not travel.
- ◆ Retain is not indecision. It is a decision with a stated reason.
- ◆ **Relocate moves infrastructure wholesale** without changing operations or re-buying hardware.

ON THE EXAM

If a scenario gives a reason an application must stay put, the answer is Retain, not a hybrid architecture.

An estate is never migrated with one strategy. It is **sorted** into seven piles.

The three phases AWS names

01

Assess

Understand what you have and build the business case.

02

Mobilise

Close skill gaps, build a landing zone, pilot a few applications.

03

Migrate and modernise

Move at scale, then improve what you moved.

ON THE EXAM

Discovery and business-case tooling belongs to Assess. That is why those services appear in questions about early-stage planning.

The migration tooling in scope

SERVICE	WHAT IT IS FOR
AWS Application Discovery Service	Inventories on-premises servers and their usage. Assess phase.
Migration Evaluator	Builds the cost business case for moving. Assess phase.
AWS Migration Hub	One place to track migration progress across tools and Regions.
AWS Application Migration Service	Lift and shift of servers. The rehost tool.
AWS Database Migration Service	Moves the data, with the source database still running.
AWS Schema Conversion Tool	Converts schema and code between different database engines.

ON THE EXAM

Discovery inventories, Evaluator costs it, Hub tracks it, Application Migration Service moves servers, DMS moves data, SCT converts schema.

DMS or SCT?

AWS DMS

Moves the data

- Source stays online during the migration
- Continuous replication keeps target in sync
- Minimal downtime at cutover
- Works for same-engine or different-engine moves

AWS SCT

Converts the structure

- Tables, views, stored procedures, functions
- Only needed for different-engine moves
- Flags what it cannot convert automatically
- Run before DMS, not instead of it

THE TIEBREAKER

SCT handles the schema, DMS handles the rows. Same engine on both sides means you need DMS only.

Homogeneous or heterogeneous

- ◆ **Homogeneous** means the same engine on both sides. Oracle to Oracle, MySQL to MySQL.
- ◆ The schema already fits, so DMS alone is enough.
- ◆ **Heterogeneous** means different engines. Oracle to Amazon Aurora PostgreSQL.
- ◆ The schema will not fit, so SCT converts it first, then DMS moves the data.
- ◆ DMS Schema Conversion is a managed version of SCT inside the DMS console.

ON THE EXAM

Different engine means two tools. Same engine means one. That single word decides the answer.

Discovery Service or Migration Evaluator?

APPLICATION DISCOVERY SERVICE

What have we got?

- Inventories servers and dependencies
- Collects configuration and usage data
- Technical input for planning
- Feeds Migration Hub

MIGRATION EVALUATOR

What would it cost?

- Builds a cost comparison and business case
- Directed at finance and executives
- Output is a projection, not an inventory
- Used to get the migration approved

THE TIEBREAKER

Technical inventory means Discovery Service. A business case or cost projection means Migration Evaluator.

Application Migration Service and Migration Hub

- ◆ **AWS Application Migration Service** is the recommended way to rehost servers onto AWS.
- ◆ It replicates servers continuously while they keep running, then cuts over with minimal downtime.
- ◆ If a question says lift and shift with no application changes, this is the service.
- ◆ **AWS Migration Hub** tracks progress across migration tools and Regions in one place.
- ◆ Migration Hub does not move anything. It is a dashboard, and that is the distractor.

ON THE EXAM

Application Migration Service moves servers. DMS moves databases. Migration Hub watches both and moves nothing.

What has changed here

- ◆ **The AWS Snow Family used to live in this module.** It is closed to new customers and off the in-scope list.
- ◆ Snowball support ends in commercial Regions on 31 December 2026.
- ◆ **Older banks still use Snowball as the offline bulk transfer answer.** On the exam, that answer still stands.
- ◆ In practice the successors are AWS DataSync, the AWS Data Transfer Terminal, and Direct Connect.
- ◆ DMS Fleet Advisor also reached end of support on 20 May 2026. It is not in scope.

ON THE EXAM

Module 22 covers this properly. Answer from the documented catalogue; know the reality so it does not unsettle you.

A company runs a Java application on Linux servers in its own data centre, with a self-managed PostgreSQL database on separate hardware. The data centre lease expires in five months.

The migration team moves the Java application onto EC2 instances with no code changes at all, and moves the database onto Amazon RDS for PostgreSQL.

Which migration strategy describes what happened to the database?

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| ☐ A Rehost | ☐ B Replatform |
| ☐ C Refactor | ☐ D Repurchase |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which migration strategy describes what happened to the database?

A Rehost

Correct for the Java application, which moved unchanged. Wrong for the database, which moved onto a managed service.

C Refactor

Nothing was rewritten. The schema and the application code are unchanged.

B Replatform

Self-managed PostgreSQL became Amazon RDS. A managed service replaced a component.

D Repurchase

No software was abandoned for a subscription. The company still runs its own database.

THE SIGNAL

One estate, two strategies. Read which component the question is asking about.

An insurer must migrate an Oracle database to Amazon Aurora PostgreSQL. The database contains several hundred stored procedures written in Oracle PL/SQL.

The business requires that the existing Oracle database stays available to users throughout, with only a brief cutover window at the end.

Which two services should the insurer use? (Choose two.)

- ☐ A AWS Database Migration Service
- ☐ B AWS Schema Conversion Tool
- ☐ C AWS Application Migration Service
- ☐ D AWS Migration Hub
- ☐ E AWS Backup

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two services should the insurer use? (Choose two.)

- A** AWS Database Migration Service
Moves the data while the source stays online, with continuous replication and a brief cutover.
- B** AWS Schema Conversion Tool
Different engines, so the schema and the PL/SQL procedures must be converted first.
- C** AWS Application Migration Service
Rehosts whole servers. This is a database engine change, not a server move.
- D** AWS Migration Hub
Tracks progress across tools. Useful alongside, but it migrates nothing itself.
- E** AWS Backup
Backs up AWS resources. A restore is not a migration path between different engines.

THE SIGNAL

Oracle to PostgreSQL is heterogeneous, so two tools. Stored procedures make SCT unavoidable.

A manufacturer is planning to leave its data centre. Before committing, the board wants a projection of what running the same workloads on AWS would cost compared with the current estate, in a form the finance director can review.

Nobody has yet produced a list of what is actually running on the four hundred servers.

Which two services should the manufacturer start with? (Choose two.)

- ☐ A AWS Application Discovery Service
- ☐ B Migration Evaluator
- ☐ C AWS Pricing Calculator
- ☐ D AWS Application Migration Service
- ☐ E AWS Cost Explorer

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two services should the manufacturer start with? (Choose two.)

- A** AWS Application Discovery Service
Nobody knows what is running. This inventories the servers and their usage first.
- B** Migration Evaluator
Builds the cost comparison and business case the board asked for.
- C** AWS Pricing Calculator
Estimates AWS cost, but you must already know what to model. It does not compare against the current estate.
- D** AWS Application Migration Service
Execution, not assessment. The company has not decided to migrate yet.
- E** AWS Cost Explorer
Analyses AWS spend that has already happened. There is no AWS spend yet.

THE SIGNAL

Before committing and nobody has produced a list both place this firmly in the Assess phase.

During a discovery exercise, a retailer finds three systems it had forgotten about. A reporting tool has had no logins for fourteen months. A payroll system must stay on premises until a regulator approves the move, which will take at least a year.

A customer support ticketing system is being replaced with a commercial SaaS subscription that the support team has already chosen.

Which strategies apply, in the order the systems are described?

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ A Retire, Retain, Repurchase | ☐ B Retire, Relocate, Refactor |
| ☐ C Retain, Retire, Repurchase | ☐ D Retire, Retain, Replatform |

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which strategies apply, in the order the systems are described?

- A

 Retire, Retain, Repurchase
No logins in fourteen months is retire. Blocked by a regulator is retain. Replaced by a SaaS subscription is repurchase.
- B

 Retire, Relocate, Refactor
Relocate means moving, and the payroll system is not moving. Nothing is being rewritten either.
- C

 Retain, Retire, Repurchase
First two are swapped. The unused system is retired; the blocked one is retained.
- D

 Retire, Retain, Replatform
Replatform keeps your software and swaps a component. Here the software is abandoned entirely.

THE SIGNAL

This is the portfolio pattern: one estate, three systems, three different strategies, each signalled by one clause.

What to carry out of this module

- ◆ **Ask what happened to the application.** Unchanged, tweaked, replaced, rewritten, deleted, left alone, moved wholesale.
- ◆ **Rehost changes nothing.** Replatform swaps a component for a managed service.
- ◆ **Different database engines means SCT then DMS.** Same engine means DMS alone.
- ◆ Discovery Service inventories, Migration Evaluator costs it, Migration Hub tracks it and moves nothing.
- ◆ The Snow Family is off the in-scope list, but old banks still answer with it.

ON THE EXAM

Estates get sorted into seven piles, not migrated with one strategy. Expect questions that mix them.